



BOARD MEETING MINUTES

Friday, October 2, 2025

10:00 AM

Palmetto Unified School District

1735 Haviland Circle, Columbia, SC 29210

Mission Statement: Palmetto Unified School District and South Carolina Department of Corrections will provide students with relevant courses, highly effective career related vocational programs and necessary life skills to make a positive impact in society.

Vision: Palmetto Unified School District educates and empowers participants to become employable, self-sufficient citizens.

Board of Trustee Members Present/Absent:

Rev. Dr. Robert Reid

Ms. Karen Tucker (Virtual)

Rev. Ronald Bessant

Dr. M. Elaine Richardson

Dr. James Anne Sheley (Virtual)

PUSD District Office Staff Present/Absent:

Dr. Beverly Holiday, Interim Supt./Dir. of Adult Educ.

Ms. Latasha Reaves, Registrar

Mr. Rodney Zimmerman, Director of Curriculum

Ms. Nancy Jeter, Testing Administrator

Dr. Matt Thompson, Director of CTE/Voc. Programs

Mr. Josh Brade, IT Manager

Dr. Charlette Taylor, Coordinator of Federal Programs

Mr. Russell Salter, IT Systems Administrator

Ms. Bazella Glover, Administrative Coord./HR Liaison

Rev. Dr. R. Reid, called the meeting to order at 10:01 a.m. and requested if the meeting was duly exercised in accordance with the Freedom of Information Act. He acknowledged the Board members present virtually and members at the meeting. A quorum was established with the presence of three face-to-face Board Members and two virtual Board members, total of five Board Members to meet quorum. Rev. Dr. Reid continued by leading the Board members in the Pledge of Allegiance.

Rev. R. Bessant led the invocation due to Chaplain McMillan from Camille Graham being stuck in traffic. Rev. R. Bessant prayed that the Lord orders our path and steps and that we (PUSD Family) continue to be successful in making things better for the students and population we serve.

OLD BUSINESS:

Rev. Dr. R. Reid requested approval of the Board minutes from July 11, 2025. Rev. Reid led with a motion to approve the minutes with the necessary corrections of the July 11th Board meeting.

Rev. R. Bessant seconded the motion approving the July 11, 2025, Board meeting. Motion was carried with a unanimous vote.

NEW BUSINESS:

Dr. B. Holiday introduced the Interim Deputy Director of Programs, Reentry and Rehabilitative Services, Ms. Lisa Engram, to provide the status of the vacant Superintendent's position since the retirement of Dr. Cash-Greene. Ms. Engram shared that Dr. Holiday would serve as Interim Superintendent until the position is filled. Also, Ms. Engram said that "she was told yesterday, the position was approved for posting, therefore, we are moving forward to have the position filled as soon as we can get a viable candidate." She further said, "The Director has been very, very good with helping us get positions, and getting them posted quickly since we are gradually able to post positions from our recent issues with personnel resources." So, this is where we are on the posting of the Superintendent's position. I want to thank Dr. Holiday for stepping in and doing an excellent job in the role until the position is filled.

INTERIM SUPERINTENDENT'S REPORT:

Dr. B. Holiday - Good Morning, Board of Trustees Members. Dr. B. Holiday thanked the staff for all they are doing, as well as for taking on additional duties to help continue moving the District forward. We must continue to function as one "TEAM" despite the staff shortages and reductions. Dr. Holiday asked Ms. Glover to provide the budget report in the absence of Ms. Georganna Martin.

Ms. B. Glover - Good morning, you should have the Budget Report in your folder. Based on the information from Finance, we are in good financial shape for the First Quarter of this school year. We expect payroll to increase later in the school year. Also, all EFA funds and EIA funds. She then provided an overview of the current budget. It looks really good for the fiscal year, and we should have a good year ahead of us. The agency's budget allowance, as well as the Department of Education's, is very similar to last year's. The District is in a good place financially. Are there any questions?

Dr. B. Holiday, thank you, Ms. Glover, for the Budget Report. Now, Mr. R. Zimmerman, Director of Curriculum, will give us the curriculum update.

Mr. R. Zimmerman - Good morning, To Board Chair Dr. Quinn in his absence, Members of the Board, Director Engram, ladies and gentlemen, good morning again. This morning, I will give you an update on the curriculum side of the division. I will also include information concerning our school district plan.

This morning, I will provide you with updates on the Palmetto Unified School District Strategic Plan and review the goals with you. This is our fifth year working on our District Strategic Plan, which is the last year of the plan. We believe this year's success is that we've kept the goals in front of you and our staff. By consistently providing the staff with these goals, they understand precisely what we, as a district, are trying to accomplish.

The First Goal says that by 2026, 90 to 100% of our students will show a 5% increase in the trust level of staff over preliminary schools, once placed in their current location. So, each year, as you look at the data, you can see we are making progress. In 2023, we had 89% of our students talking about how much they trust our staff in terms of preparing them for their exams and mastery of particular skill sets. In 2024, we increased that to 91%. As you can see, we are already within reach of that goal, because, again, the goal is 90% to 100%, whereas this past year, 2024-2025, the data reflected 92%. So that's goal #1.

Goal number 2-A of the District's Strategic Plan says that by June 2026, all students/inmates entering PUSD will be assessed to determine placement and educational pathways. What we are saying here is that when they (the student inmates) get to us, we are going to assess them to see where they are academically, so that we put them on an education pathway to success (i.e., High School Equivalency (GED) or high school diploma, post-secondary studies). So, what does the data say? In 2023, 82% of students entering PUSD were assessed. Based on the data, we increased awareness of what the data indicated. We then put programs/procedures in place to monitor progress.

This led to an increase to 89% in 2023-2024. This past year, again, keeping these goals in front of the staff and everyone allowed everyone to see and know exactly what we're trying to do, resulting in an increase to 95%, which means that 95% of the students who enter the institutions are properly assessed. We are looking for 100% as we move forward. So again, for the increase for 2024 -2025 to 95%. I want to give everyone a hand clap for this accomplishment.

Goal number 2-B states that by 2026, PUSD will ensure 80% of the students who enter without a credential will exit with at least one work readiness credential, including a High School Diploma, High School Equivalency Diploma, CTE credential, employee visa skills, or US DOL Apprenticeship. As you can see in the chart, this was a little tougher; in 2023, only 56% of our students exited with a credential. In 2023-2024, 66% of our students left with some type of credential. For the 2024 -2025 school year, the percentage increased to 69%. (Be reminded that this data is based on our EFA students).

So, we are really pushing in the area. We are setting benchmarks this year because the goal percentage is currently 69.2, and we are trying to get it up to 80%. So, instead of waiting until March of that year to see where the students are or what problems may be hindering us from reaching this particular goal, we now conduct quarterly data reviews. In other words, we will pull the data in October. This allows us to see where we are at specific points in the year (in a progress report). If the data review reflects progress, we will continue to monitor and move forward. If the review indicates we are off target, necessary adjustments will be made to address possible concerns or issues that may be impeding progress. So again, this is goal 2B.

Goal number 3 states that by 2026, 90% to 100% of our teachers will be appropriately certified at the secondary level. The data you see in front of you states that in 2023, 87% of our teachers were certified in secondary education. In 2023- 2024, we reached 89% of our teachers being certified at the secondary level. However, over the past year, we dropped to 87% because we lost teachers who held secondary certification. We expect the percentage to increase in the 2025-2026 school year, as we have hired secondary-certified teachers. I want to give a shout-out to those teachers who have elementary certification. They are doing an excellent job and producing many GEDs. As for the percentage of secondary Certified staff, those numbers will definitely go back up. You will see later in my presentation how we are trying to ensure our teachers maintain certification. This was a quick update on our District Strategic Plan. Are there any questions about the plan?

Rev. Dr. R. Reid asked the question, "Are we still under a hiring freeze right now for the teachers, and how many are we short?"

Interim Director L. Engram replied that, as for the agency, it is not necessarily a freeze. It is a staggered hiring process. She stated, "Two months ago, we were only hiring security personnel. We are now allowed to hire in this division." We were able to hire in five positions within the month, so it's opening up. For the past two years, it's only been critical positions. So, I am hopeful that over the next couple of months, we'll see more hiring here. Per the Interim Director, the focus is on hiring in the institutional services, so not necessarily the administrative services, but services that are directly based in the institutions.

Are there any other questions?

Thank you.

Mr. R. Zimmerman, please be reminded that this is the last year of the 5-year Strategic Plan. Next year we start over again for another five years.

Additional updates from the Curriculum Area: Mentoring and Induction Program Update. The State Department of Education requires that every school district have a Mentor Teacher and Induction (first-year teacher) Program. We do have a Mentor and Induction Teacher Program here in PUSD. Last year, we had 12 mentors trained by the state. Those mentors are assigned to our induction/new teachers. Whenever we bring in a teacher or a new teacher to work in corrections, they are assigned a mentor to help the new teacher/induction teacher develop as they adjust to the system/environment. Again, we have 12 mentors trained.

Next is Teacher Evaluation and Support. In our effort to support our teachers, we use the State Department of Education SCLead Data Management System. This system allows us to conduct teacher evaluations and provide teacher support. This tool will enable us to evaluate teachers and provide support to ensure they receive what they need to provide the best instruction in the classroom. We have conducted an orientation to ensure teachers understand the evaluation and support tool. The evaluation of our teachers is ongoing during the fall and spring semesters. We have already begun our fall evaluations.

I spoke about this earlier, Teacher Certification. Teacher certification is always ongoing. Notification concerning certificate renewal is ongoing because again, we work to maintain certified teachers in the classroom. Also, for professional development, teachers can earn credit toward renewing their certificate.

As for Professional Development, we use it to build teacher capacity and provide continuous growth and development for our staff. On yesterday the State Department came in and we held a special education session. The session focused on SCed Plan. The session was very successful, and a follow-up session is planned.

Our next professional development will be on Friday, October 31st, and at that time we will again discuss best practices for classroom instruction. We will cover areas that ensure our teachers are exposed to information that supports effective classroom instruction. Here at the district office, we continuously work to ensure we do all we can to give our teachers what they need to be successful in the classroom and to increase student learning. This ends my presentation. Are there any questions?

Next, we will have Dr. Taylor, Coordinator of Federal Programs, to present.

Dr. C. Taylor – The EFA enrollment is 164 as of today. The high school diploma goal for this year is 3, but as of now, we have 0 for attainment at this time. We are still working on some transcript analyses. We recommend eligible students for the high school pathway so we can have more working toward that goal.

Any questions?

Thank you.

Dr. B. Holiday – Good morning, everyone. Dr. B. Holiday reported that all 21 schools in the district are striving to help the district reach its goal. Our High School Equivalency goal for this school year is 279. As of today, district-wide our students have achieved the following credentials: 19 High School Equivalency Diplomas, 637 CTE/Vocational Certificates, 645 Employability, Career, Work Readiness Credentials, 0 Dept of Labor Apprenticeship Credentials, and 735 On-the-Job Training Certificates (OJT certificates are no longer counted as an educational goal), for a grand total of 2,036 credentials. As you can see, we are moving towards achieving our goal, and I know we will exceed it. Dr. Taylor already presented the High School Diploma goal. She stated that as of this date, we do not have any students who have completed their High School Diploma; however, our district's goal for High School Diplomas is three. We have both EFA and adult students on the High School Diploma, so we are hopeful that they will attain their diplomas this year.

Rev. R. Reid challenged Dr. Taylor to increase the number of High School Diplomas from three to five, as he feels it can be done.

Any questions?

Thank you, now let's hear from Dr. Thompson.

Dr. M. Thompson – Good morning. I'll be providing updates on our CTE educational programs. For 25-26, our CTE Goal is 1,600 credentials. As of September 30, 2025, we have awarded 494 certificates. That puts us roughly 31% of the way towards the year's goal. During the 24-25 academic year, we have awarded 597 credentials to date. We're also down a few instructors this year compared to last year. We're a little bit behind where we were, but we're still on pace to meet that goal.

Next is the Department of Labor Apprenticeships. We are not on pace to meet the Department of Labor goal. Our goal for the year is 16. Currently, we have zero Department of Labor apprenticeships. Those certificates are rather labor-intensive for a student to earn. At this time, we have nine students who are registered for their DOL, and those nine should be completed by February. I'm actively seeking and working with other individuals throughout the agency to identify others who may be eligible for their DOL.

The next topic is CTE budgeting. Our regular agency funding has now been allocated to our instructors, and they're actively ordering the materials needed. As for our Perkins & State grant, the application is still pending approval. I have an update meeting with the State Department of Education in two weeks. Hopefully, by that point, our Perkins application will have been approved. That's usually the point where they tell everybody their status.

As for our current CTE enrollment, we have 740 CT seats across the district. On July 1, 2025, 73% of those seats were occupied. At the beginning of October, 85% of the seats are occupied; so we're steadily increasing enrollment.

Next up is industry credentialing. I'll first report on iCEV credentialing. We have 250 seats across the district, and currently 182 students are enrolled in iCEV. Our students have earned 189 credentials across 15 different certification areas.

As for NCCER, we have 200 seats. That's our construction certification. 165 seats have been utilized thus far. 63% of those have resulted in a credential. And of those 63 percent, 104 students have earned a total of 181 credentials. We have 35 more subscription seats to assign to students throughout the district, and those expire on January 5, 2026. In the next month or so, we will make our last push to ensure everybody in those construction trades is assigned a seat ready for testing.

The ASE academic year just recently began. MacDougall has ten seats assigned. One student has tested for MacDougall and passed all four areas in their respective automotive trade. McCormick has five seats. No testing has occurred there yet. Tyger River has 15 seats, and one student has tested. He passed all four of his tests. That student actually got out of prison two days ago and already has a job. He is the individual highlighted by Mr. Davis Anderson (PRRS Workforce Development).

ServSafe for 24-25, we had 100 subscriptions, which recently expired. All 100 were used. 91 credentials were earned for ServSafe. For 25-26, we're requesting 50 subscriptions, and right now we're awaiting a quote from the vendor. We can't really move on until the vendor gives us the quote for those seats.

And finally, EPA testing for the year. For 24-25, our final count was 10 subscriptions. All ten seats were used, and all ten students earned their full EPA license. And for 25-26, we have 10 subscriptions. Those seats are already available for the instructor to use. We've tested zero at this point. However, those seats don't expire until September 2026, so we have a while before then. They will certainly be utilized.

And finally, I want to invite everyone here to the SCDC Fall Hobby Craft and Plant Sale over at the Headquarters Ballfield. As soon as you go through the main SCDC gates, you make the first right as soon as you pass through the gates. Over in the ball field to the left, we have our horticulture programs throughout the agency. They will have plants for sale. Also, our welding and carpentry programs have items produced by students available for purchase.

That concludes my report. Are there any questions for me?

Thank you.

Dr. B. Holiday – Thank you, Dr. Thompson, for the update on CTE/Vocational Education. Next, Dr. B. Holiday provided a brief human resources update. We currently have 75 staff members. Eight employees resigned or retired from the last school year until now: (Mr. Robert Jones, Mr. Thomas Nicholson, Mr. Arthur Gill, Jon Baldree, David Saverance, Ms. Jessica Pisa, Ms. Nancy Hart, and Dr. Cynthia Cash-Greene).

Rev. Dr. R. Reid suggested the Board of Trustees send the retired staff members a letter of "Thanks for what they have done for this organization." All Board Members agreed with the suggestion of Rev. Dr. R. Reid.

Also, we have three new staff members: (Mr. Kristy Covey, who will be providing instruction to the DJJ population of students that are housed at Broad River, Ms. Karen Joyner-Washington who will be teaching at Camille Graham and Goodman, and Mr. Ryan Bartola, a returning SPED teacher who will be teaching at Broad River and Kirkland and serving as our SPED Coordinator.

After the Human Resources update, Dr. B. Holiday presented the post-secondary update.

POST-SECONDARY UPDATE:

Dr. B. Holiday shared that as of September 25, 2025, there were 178 total scholars enrolled in post-secondary partnership colleges/universities: Benedict College - (23 students between Broad River and Kershaw Correctional Institutions), Claflin University - (68 between Camille Graham, Ridgeland, and Trenton Correctional Institutions), Columbia International University - (16 at Kirkland Correctional Institution), Denmark Technical College - (30 at Allendale Correctional Institution), Florence-Darlington Technical College - (9 at Palmer Correctional Institution), Northeastern Technical College - (13 at Evans Correctional Institution), Technical College of the Lowcountry - (13 at Ridgeland Correctional Institution), Voorhees University - (13 at MacDougall Correctional Institution).

Also, Dr. B. Holiday shared that Morris College is planning to begin hosting classes at Lee, Turbeville, and Wateree River Correctional Institutions in the summer semester of 2026. Additionally, Dr. B. Holiday reported that Dr. C. Taylor will be working with the post-secondary partners since the retirement of Dr. C. Cash-Greene.

After the post-secondary report, Dr. M. Elaine Richardson introduced Dr. S. Madison (a prospective new Board Member, as her name has been submitted to the SCDC Director's Office for appointment to the PUSD Board of Trustees). Dr. S. Madison gave a brief overview of her current role as a professor in the College of Education at Clemson University and her previous role as a Spanish teacher for ten years. Dr. S. Madison shared some of the things she has done previously (involvement with immigration detention centers, doing humanitarian visits and volunteering, working at a facility in Georgia, etc.), all of which became a part of her dissertation research. Afterwards, Dr. M. E. Richardson shared with us a book, "Flying Kites -Narratives of Prison Literacies in Essays and Art," that Dr. S. Madison co-authored. Dr. M. E. Richardson encouraged us to get a copy of the book because the essays are written by incarcerated individuals.

Rev. Dr. R. Reid, Dr. Sheley, and Ms. Tucker all agreed that they would love to have a 'donated, signed copy of the book.

Dr. M. E. Richardson shared that Dr. Otis Pickett would be joining Clemson as a University Historian. Dr. Pickett taught courses at Parchman Penitentiary and Central Mississippi Correctional Facility through the Prison to College Pipeline Program.

Dr. M. E. Richardson stated that the emeritus college is very active, and there is a group working on ways to support higher education. The college emeritus members cannot do anything at the university level to initiate a new program; it must be a current faculty member, so this is what Dr. Pickett is doing, and he has a lot of support with this initiative.

Rev. Dr. R. Reid asked Dr. M. E. Richardson, when Dr. Taylor was presenting her report on online courses, whether inmates can now take online classes through Clemson University. Dr. M. E. replied, "This is what we will be looking into and trying to figure out if there is a way we can do that.

Dr. Richardson said the emeritus faculty are involved in so many things at the university, and they could teach classes in the higher education program. It would be good if we could figure out how to teach the courses online, since other states are doing so.

Rev. Dr. R. Reid stated, "As you know, I am not Chairman Quinn. At the July Board Meeting, Chairman Quinn said he was resigning because he had other commitments. He is stepping down, and we have two other vacancies. Dr. B. Holiday also shared that Mr. T. Grinstead notified her and stated that his term had ended and that he would like to resign from the Board. In addition to Mr. M. Sumter's resignation earlier in the year to take a position in Georgia, his seat was also vacant.

Rev. Dr. R. Reid asked the question, "When do you think these vacant positions will be filled?" Dr. B. Holiday explained to him that the process is multi-layered and takes a minute to fill the Board of Trustees Members' seats. Interim Deputy Director L. Engram also shared that several Board Members' terms had expired and that those members need to be reappointed to their seats. She further stated that SCDC has four seats and the three vacant Board seats at SCDC, the Director had submitted their letters and names for appointment to the PUSD Board of Trustees to the Office of SC Secretary of State, Boards and Commissions.

Interim Deputy Director L. Engram also stated we needed to contact the State Superintendent of Education (four Board of Trustees seats) and the Governor's Office (one Board of Trustees seat) to see if they wanted to extend the individuals who were appointed by them or appoint new members to fill all nine PUSD Board of Trustees seats.

Rev. Dr. R. Reid asked, "how long do we anticipate before the Board seats are be filled?" Interim Director Engram stated, "hopefully, we should have all Board Members in place within 30 days, but it depends on other people responses. We are hopeful all Board Members will be in named and in place before the next Board meeting in January 2026."

Rev. Dr. R. Reid said he asked the question because we have the election of officers, and that's an action item. Rev. Dr. R. Reid asked if the Board would rather wait until January, when all Board Members were in place, to appoint the Chairman and Vice Chairman? It was decided that it would be better to wait until all Board seats were filled before a Chairman and Vice Chairman are appointed. Rev. Dr. R. Reid will continue to serve in the role of acting Chairman until a Chairman of the Board is named.

EXECUTIVE SESSION:

No Executive Session was needed.

BOARD MEMBERS REPORT/COMMENTS:

Dr. J. A. Sheley – I appreciate everyone's work.

Ms. K. Tucker – I am here; no questions.

Dr. J. A. Sheley – Before we sign off, this is James Anne. Can someone check and make sure that I'm still on the Board?

Rev. Dr. R. Reid – We will move to adjournment.

The meeting adjourned at approximately 11:00 a.m.